

HIST225 Week 1

2.3

Religion -> *religo*: to tie, to bind

- Respect for what is sacred: awe, piety, rituals, etc.
- We are tied to that which is beyond us humans (God, spirits, universe, etc.)
- What is NOT HUMAN

Religion as an Umbrella Term for Scholarly Study:

- Term used to explain how we organize in communities (relationships) & answer ultimate/universal concerns/questions of all humans (?)
 - Why life/death; good/bad; how we are to be human (what is human); what is beyond us (divinity)?
- acknowledges organized systems that hold people together (Durkheim) → worldviews, traditions, practices, beliefs, ethics, etc.

Working definition: religion is a diverse category of human experiences, organizes people & helps them make sense of reality, which includes being tied to that which is beyond the human (divine, non-human, nature, etc.)

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Magic = no universal academic definition

- Historically, a negative contrast to religion & science → “illegitimate” or “primitive” form
- ethnocentric & deviance theory: product of modern Western culture & an “attack” tool in interreligious conflict

Etymology: from *magos* (Greek; pl. *magoi*)

- Priestly caste [status-occupation] in the Persian empire who did rites and ceremonies (mageia)

Working Definition: magic = human control of supernatural forces (an act of human agency in the world)

- lookout for cross-cultural “patterns of magicity” (e.g., ritual use of words → “spells”)

Miracle...similarly, there is no one standard way to define

- cross-cultural & cross-religious, however...
- Western/Christian focus & bias: miracles/signs of prophets, esp. Jesus → show either power of God (via intermediary) OR who Christ is (divine)

Etymology: from *miraculum* (Latin): “an object of wonder”

- mirror: “I marvel at, admire, am amazed, wonder”

Working Definition: a miracle = event that so defies expectations of the laws of nature that it is presumed that it is supernatural in origin (an act of divine agency made manifest in the world)

Magos as a Term of Abuse VS. Historical Reality:

- authentic Magi: hereditary technologists from Iran (Persia)
- charlatans?: Greeks treated Persians as “the Other”

A Limited Scholarly Picture of Historical Magi:

- who: wandering figures (Persian or Hellenized) in the 5th c. BCE onwards
- what: practiced incantations (charms, songs, whispering) → murmuring = magic/var/home/magland/Notes/HIST225

Exam

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- represent: anxiety over outsiders/foreigners who threatened status quo (e.g., Medea, the non-Greek witch)
- implications: Greeks were dissatisfied with traditional religion (public cult/society) → private/mystery cult (individual)

HIST225 Week 2

2.10

Control, or responding to lack of control (environment)

Ancient Near East (ANE)

Mesopotamia (focus: c. 4000-330 BCE)

ANE → Mesopotamia = mixed region of empires over time (modern day Iraq)

- Fertile Crescent Region: Tigris-Euphrates rivers = “cradle of civilization”
- Permanent settlement = cultural innovation: transition from hunter-gathering to agricultural societies (Neolithic Revolution: 10000 BCE onwards)

Magic in the Ancient Near East

Cosmotheology: worshipping cosmos as a whole (the Oneness)

- multiplicity of gods based in nature/concepts
- humans (clay + blood of gods) = born to serve gods
- daily life is a battle: good vs. evil → most magic = defensive

Magician/Exorcist (Asipu): hereditary & skilled occupation (male)

- temple rituals (cleaning/feed statues, installing priests)
- rituals for kings (installing them, protecting their reign)
- fighting evil (demons/witches/curses) & healing (medicine)

Developed divination as science: *divine messages from movement of heavens*

- astrology (star lore) & extispicy (reading animal entrails)
- zodiac (460 BCE) → 410 BCE 1st horoscope to predict individual's fate

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Egyptomania: 19th century obsession with Egypt

- Imperialism → Napoleons Egyptian campaign led to interest, especially after translations project of the Rosetta Stone → form of Orientalism
- Egyption Revival → part of “occult” iconography

Ancient Egypt

c. 6000 BCE to 30 CE

- Two Kingdoms: Upper & Lower Egypt
- Theocracy: ruled by pharaohs = incarnation of the god Horus

Not Obsessed with Death, but Life:

- rebirth into afterlife → must be buried in Egypt

- Nile's flood cycles → orient calendar/daily life
- universality in flux: harmony/balance VS. chaos

Magic (*Heka*) as Basic Cosmic Force

- Power created by gods to ward off evil & influence others = ALL subject to it
- Wab-priests: hereditary occupation to care for statues (bodies for gods)
- Pyrami

HIST225 Week 3

2.17

Spell: words or formula that have magic power & impact when recited or performed

Enchant: to attract, delight, charm; to cast a spell on

- Old French → Latin: *incanto* (sing)

Curse: a supernatural detriment or hinderance; prayer that harm may befall someone; cause of great harm

Binding Magic via Inscribed Objects: formulas to invoke supernatural powers to do action or control others

- defixio/kortadesmos → to bind/fasten down
- thin sheets of lead/lead alloys or figurines w/ nails @ liminal places like tombs/doorways

The 4-Fold Relationship of a Curse

- client, specialist, god/ghost victim
- chthonic deities & unburied dead

Thematic Trends: Cursing (Greek & Roman) vs. Protection (Jewish)

- Competition
- Matters of the heart
- Protection/revenge

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Hinduism

- focus: escape (*moksha*) from reincarnation (*samsara*)
- polytheistic oneness: 33 million devas help on path

Material Change/Control of Higher Principles of Natural Law via Supernatural Powers

1. train via **yoga meditation** to obtain powers (*siddhi*)
 - understanding dharma (law)
 - e.g., conquer death
2. popular piety of wonder (*adbhuta*) → divine power acts in world via icons (*murti*) or human teachers (*guru*)
 - so what: showcase eternal truth of universe's Oneness via the many (not single God)

Buddhism

- focus: eliminate the suffering (*dukkha*) of desiring permanence (everything is temporary)
- Buddha (the Awakened One; Prince Siddhartha/avatar of Vishnu in Hinduism)

Miracles are Natural via Mental Training

- six higher knowledges via meditation
- monastic le: no display of miraculous power (does not add faith → “cheap tricks”)
- so what: miracles can inspire (miracle of instruction)

Chinese Magic

“This-World” / Present Life Focus, Not Gods/Transcendent World:

- focus: family, not gods → human ancestors ensure well-being of living (*deserve reverence*)
- worship: tombs, temples, altars, mountain tops (*di*: divine creative force)
- magical presumption: people participate directly in universe good or evil) → help it come into being
- aspects: cycle of five elements (wood-fire-metal-water-earth);

balance of yin-yang & flows of energy (*qi*)

Two Main Ways of Conversing with the Dead:

- divination via oracle bones (scapulimancy): burn/light → read cracks
- pay respects via feasts: maintain good will so you can ask questions/get help → offer favorite foods in bronze cooking vessel (*ding*) & basin (*gui*)

Chinese Astrology (c. 1,000 BCE): systemic observation of heavens to see patterns → 5 element theory, colours, animals

- course of life & character determined by hour, day, year of birth
- zodiac/horoscope: 12-year cycle (represented by animals)

HIST225 Week 4

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Pythia, High Priestess of the Temple of Apollo

- speaks for Apollo via divine “possession” (*enthusiasmos*)
- AKA” The Delphic Oracle

The Life of the Oracle

- sits on tripod delivers Apollo’s prophecies (answers questions) while inhaling vapors
- “cries” interpreted & put into verse (poetry) → often ambiguous in meaning
- performs only once a month
- evidence: 615 prophecies

Classical Period (490-323 BCE): height of Greek power and culture

- organization around the *polis*: fiercely independent city-states that make up *Hellas* (e.g., Athens, Sparta) VS. foreign invaders (Persians)

Social Value of Ancient Greek Magic

- competitive city states & society: achieve *arete* (excellence)
- cultural anxiety: respond to lack of control in life
- shame-honor binary: envy over others’ success and satisfaction

Examples by Type/Service:

- communication

- products
- transformations

Pharmakeia: using herbs to make medicines, potions, poisons

- *pharmakon*: a drug → the power to harm AND heal (depending on dosage)

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Divination: the art of discovering secrets/future by means beyond the normal or natural

- *divinō* “I foresee”
- gods respond to questions via oracles (*ōrāculum*: “divine announcements”) → Delphic Oracle

Augury: interpretation of omens/signs, especially the behaviours of birds

- Romans: figure out will of gods before major actions

Haruspicy: divination via sacrificial animal entrails (especially the liver)

- Etruscan origins (pre-Romans in Italy)

Ancient Rome (c. 625 BCE - 476 CE)

- militaristic culture & imperial expansion: Pax Romana (*Roman Peace*) Pax Deorum (*Peace of the Gods*) → a period of “peace & prosperity” (27 BCE - 180 CE)

Traditional Ancestral Religion in the Classical World → the Public Cult

- tied to political life
- rituals & festivals → Panhellenic vs. local vs. family
- ex. Olympian pantheon, local gods, household shrines
- contractual relationship with gods: give gods what they deserve → leave humanity alone OR help in present life, not about belief or salvation after death
- Romans more animistic (*spirits in everything*)

Roman Magic: based off Greek magic

- insider vs. outsider logic: help yourself (crops, health) VS. “foreign” use
- Skepticism of false/improper religion & medical practices
- practice seen as opposite to public cult

Greco-Roman Miracles

Greco-Roman Wonderment, not Faith

- *thauma*: “a wonder, marvel, something strange” & *signum*: “a sign, mark, or symbol” → observe something out of the ordinary
- polytheism not about conversion

Purpose of Miracles: Two options

- signpost a crisis because of divine offence
- expansion of local pantheon → importing new god = establish new sanctuary

2.28

Sacred: characterized by solemn religious ceremony or use (positive)

- Sacralum (Latin): “dedicated/devoted to” divinity, holy”

Profane: unclean; ritually impure; unholy OR relating to non-religious matters (secular)

Wheel of the Year (Wicca)

The 8 Shabbats: earth is a wheel on an axis

1. Samhain (10/13): The New Year
 - The final harvest/prep for winter
 - liminal: dead & fae
2. Yule/Solstice (12/21-12/22): The Rebirth (of the god)
 - Carnival (reversal)
 - leisure & feasting (meat)
3. Imbolic (1/31-2/2): The First Light
 - Fire+ water (purification), quickening
 - Goddess **Brighid** (exalted)
4. Beltane (4/30 or 5/1): True Consumption
 - Sexual union: god (sun) + goddess (spring)
 - Bonfire + “a-maging”
5. Litha (6/20-6/21): True Culmination
 - Midsummer
 - Green may → cut down (sacrifice), Stonehenge
6. Lughnased (8/1): The Decline

- First harvest & handfasting (marriage)
- Feasting (corn, wheat); county fairs (live stock)
- 7. Maboon (9/22-9/23): The Harvest
 - Second harvest & underworld
 - Descent & resurrection of child (male/female)

Cast Study: Yuletide Goat (Julbocu)

Traditional scandinavian Festival marks Sun's path: with Capricorn (sun's rebirth @ Solstice)

- Traditional winter sacrifice: kid goat in honor of Saturn
- Norse Myth: Thor's chariot goats → killed and revived
- Becomes a symbolic ritual: young man dresses up as goat with gifts
- Positive appropriation: straw sacrifice (replacement effigy)
- Bundle of last harvest's wheat: contains magic of last harvest spirit